KANSAS

The Sunflower State



The wind on the Kansas prairie does not politely announce itself. It arrives without warning, bending the tallgrass flat and pushing hard against anything that dares stand upright. In the 1870s, it pushed against thousands of German-Russian Mennonite immigrants who stepped off the trains at Newton and Halstead and looked out at a landscape so vast and unfamiliar it must have taken the breath clean out of them. They had left German-speaking settlements across the Russian Empire—including Mennonite communities in present-day Ukraine and Volga German communities farther east—drawn to Kansas by railroad land offers.

They brought almost nothing—but what they brought mattered enormously. Family tradition holds that they carried Turkey Red wheat seed in their trunks beside hand-stitched linens and German-language Bibles, bringing with them a legacy of farming that would help transform Kansas agriculture. But they also carried something less celebrated, something that lived in the memory of every woman who had kept a farmhouse kitchen: the recipe for the bierock.

The bierock was a working person's food, born of necessity and perfected by repetition. Ground beef or pork was cooked down with shredded cabbage and onion, seasoned simply, folded into a soft, enriched yeast dough, and baked until the outside turned golden and the inside steamed with savory filling. It could be made in quantity, carried in a basket, and eaten in a field without utensils—yet still tasted like something that took genuine love to make.

On the homesteads of Harvey, Marion, and McPherson counties, farmwives mixed the dough before dawn, filling their kitchens with a warm, yeasty smell that meant something good was coming. By midday, bierocks wrapped in cloth were making their way out to the fields, the dough soft enough to pull apart with cold, tired hands. Neighbors traded variations—a little more caraway here, a touch of pepper there—and the recipe settled into the Kansas kitchen the way the settlers settled into the land: firmly, quietly, and for good.

What makes the bierock irresistible is exactly what made it practical: everything in one golden, hand-held package. The dough is tender and barely sweet; the filling is savory and soft, the cabbage melting into the beef until the two are inseparable. Pull one apart fresh from the oven and the steam rises with a smell impossible to resist—a whole meal, and a whole history of endurance, folded neatly into something you can hold in one hand.

BIEROCK

Mennonite settlers carried this recipe across an ocean and half a continent: seasoned beef and cabbage in a golden hand-held loaf.

Yield: 8 bierocks

INGREDIENTS

DOUGH

- 1 package (2¼ tsp) active dry yeast
- ¼ cup warm water (110°F / 43°C)
- ¾ cup warm milk
- ¼ cup unsalted butter, melted
- 2 Tbsp granulated sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 egg
- 3 to 3½ cups all-purpose flour

FILLING

- 1 lb. ground beef (or a mix of beef and pork)
- 1 small onion, finely chopped
- 2 cups green cabbage, finely shredded
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- Garlic powder, caraway seeds, or shredded cheese (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Make the dough*: In a small bowl, dissolve the yeast in warm water and let sit for 5–10 minutes until foamy. In a large bowl, combine the warm milk, melted butter, sugar, salt, and egg. Add the yeast mixture. Gradually mix in the flour, one cup at a time, until a soft dough forms. Knead the dough on a floured surface for 6–8 minutes until smooth and elastic. Place in a greased bowl, cover, and let rise in a warm place for 1 hour or until doubled in size.
2. *Prepare the filling*: In a skillet over medium heat, cook the ground beef and onion until beef is browned and onion is soft. Drain any excess fat. Add cabbage, season with salt and pepper, and cook until cabbage is tender (5–10 minutes). Stir in seasonings or cheese, then remove from heat and cool slightly.
3. *Assemble the bierocks*: Preheat oven to 375°F (190°C). Punch down the risen dough and divide into 8 equal pieces. Roll each piece into a 5–6-inch circle. Spoon about ¼ cup of the filling into the center of each round. Fold the dough over the filling, pinch edges to seal tightly, and place seam-side down on a greased baking sheet.
4. *Bake*: Brush the tops with melted butter or egg wash for a golden finish. Bake for 18–22 minutes or until golden brown.

NOTES & TIPS

- Serve warm with mustard, pickles, or even a bowl of soup. They also freeze well and reheat beautifully.

